Lab: Create a Skateboard Promo Video

This lab will extend our knowledge of working with masks in Adobe After Effects as well as learning about mattes and compositions.

You've been hired to create a promo skateboard video for Broken Bones Skateboards. They given you video footage and want a montage video of cool skateboarding shots to act as the backdrop for their company logo.

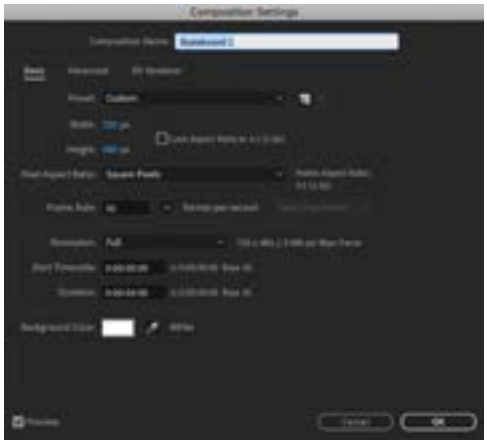
Setup

Take a moment to look at the video you will create using Adobe After Effects. You can view the video on YouTube below:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=M9_hHtfmXEw

Make sure you have downloaded all the necessary lab files from Canvas. The files are in zip folder called *After-Effects-Skateboard-Video*. Make sure to unzip the folder completely to use the files inside appropiately.

Animated Mask







Create a new project in Adobe After Effects and import the all of the files from the *Lab-Skateboard-Video* folder into the *Project* panel.

Create a new composition called *Skateboard 1*. Create a composition that is 720x480px, 30fps that is four second long. After creating the composition click and drag *Skateboard-Video-1.mp4* into the timeline.

In the last lab we discussed adding masks to hide or conceal part of our video layer. Masks in Adobe After Effects can also be animated to create interesting conceal / reveal effects.

Select the *Skateboard-Video-1* layer in the timeline and select the *Rectangle Tool* from the *Toolbar*. Click and drag over the middle of the video to create a mask. Double click on the mask to gain access to the *free transform* options. Make the mask tall and then that extends past the height of the video. Use the image on the right as a reference. don't worry if your is not 100% like the reference.

Select the *Skateboard-Video-1* layer in the timeline and press the *"M"* key to access the mask. Unfurl the mask to find the property *Mask Shape* and make sure it is highlighted. Use the *Selection Tool* to drag the mask off the stage on the left side.

Move the timemarker to the beginning of the timeline and turn on the stop watch for the *Mask Path* option. Move the time marker to the 2 second mark in the timeline. Double click on the mask to gain access to the free transform option, drag to make the mask larger to take up the entire screen.

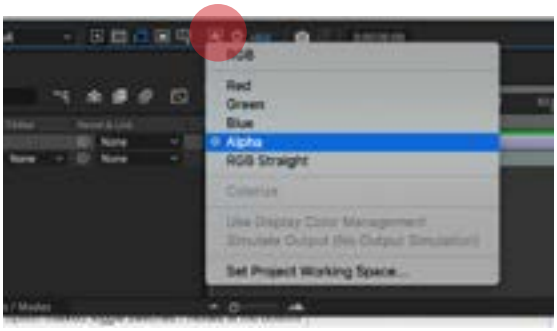


Use the *Preview* panel to play the scene and you will see the mask animate to become bigger, which in turn reveals more of the skateboarding video.

Alpha Matte



Previously we learned about how After Effects masks can determine what areas of a layer are concealed and what areas are revealed. Another way to achieve this effect is the use of *track mattes*. Track mattes are layers in your timeline that can apply transparency to other layers, this can be done with either the alpha of a layer, or the luminance of a layer.



Create a new composition called *Skateboard 2*. Set the settings to 720x480px, 30fps that is four second long. Drag *Skateboard-Video-2.mp4* video into the timeline.

Drag the file *Skull.ai* into the timleline and make sure to place it above the *Skateboard-Video-2.mp4* layer. We are going to use the *Skull.ai* file as a track matte to affect the skateboard video. More specificially we are going to use the alpha or contours of the skull layer to affect the skateboarding video.

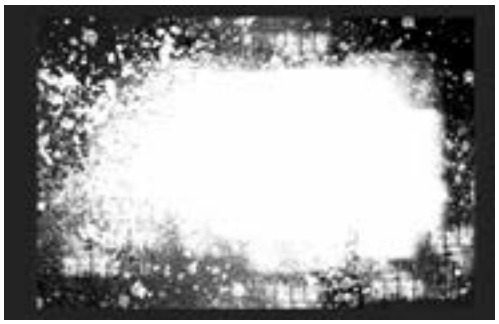


Begin by using the *solo* option in the timeline to view only the ***Skull*** layer. You can view the alpha of the skull by clicking on the option marked *Show Channel* in your composition window. Click and hold to the option marked *Alpha*, this will turn your composition window black and white. The white represents where the alpha is, the black represents what areas will be kept transparent. Set the composition back to *RGB* in the *Show Channel* option to view the scene with normal colors.



Click on the option marked *Toggle Switches / Modes* at the bottom of the application, this will reveal a column called *TrkMat* or trackmatte. Set the *TrkMat* dropdown menu to *Alpha Matte "Skull.ai"*. The alpha matte will use the alpha or filled in pixels of the skull layer to determine where the video plays. The non-alpha or transparent pixels will be kept blank. Notice that the *Skull* layer visibility toggle is turned off in the layer stack. Use the *Preview* to play the scene and watch how the video plays through the skull outline.

Luminosity Mask



Take a moment to look at *matte-grunge.jpg* in the Project panel, you'll notice it has a black background with white and light gray scratches on top. Drag in the image *matte-grunge.jpg* and place it directly above the *Skateboard-Video-2.mp4* layer in the *Skating 2* composition. Reset the track matte for the Skateboard video to the new *matte-grunge* layer as "*Alpha Matte matte grunge*". Preview the video and you'll notice that the entire video plays, this is because the *matte-grunge* image is a solid alpha so all areas of the video are shining through.



Instead of using the alpha of the *matte-grunge* layer why don't we try using the luminosity of the layer. Luminosity are the bright and dark tones of an image or video. We can create a luminosity matte where the bright tones / bright areas allow the video to shine through while the dark tones / dark areas become transparent.

Select the *TrkMat* of *Skateboard-Video-2* and set it *Luminosity "Matte-Grunge"*. Make sure the *matte-grunge* is above the skate boarding video and that the visibility is turned off. Preview the video and you will see the video playing through the brighter grunge areas of the photo.



Animated Mattes

In addition to using images as alpha or luminance mattes we can also have animated mattes as well meaning the mattes will animate and change over time.



Create a new composition called *Skateboard 3*. Set the settings to 720x480px, 30fps that is four second long. Drag *Skateboard-Video-3.mp4* video into the timeline.

Drag in the video *Animated-Alpha-Mask* and place it ABOVE the *skateboard-video-3* in the timeline. Solo the layer and take a moment to view the video. This is a special video where the alpha channel was exported with the video, this means as the rectangle move, so does the alpha components of the video. Exporting an alpha channel with a video is a possible option when exporting in Adobe After Effects.



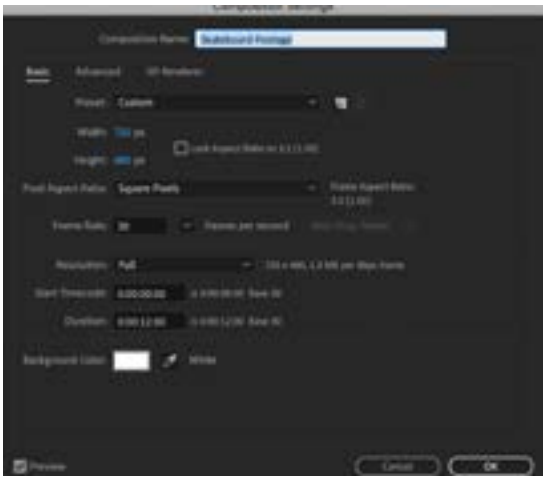
Select the *Skateboard-Video-3* and set the *TrkMat* to *"Alpha Matte Animated-Alpha-Mask"*. Preview the scene and you will see that the masks animates and parts of the scene that are visible change over time.



Drag in the video *Animated-Luminosity-Mask* into the timeline, make sure to place it above the *Skateboard-Video-3* in the layer stack. Preview the animation and you will see white rectangles moving across the page on a black background. This video would

be perfect as a luminance matte. Set the *TrkMat* option for the *Skateboard-Video-3* to *"Luminance Matte Animated-Luminosity-Mask".* Preview and you should see video now conforms to the luminance of the *animated-luminosity-mask* layer.

Composition Nesting

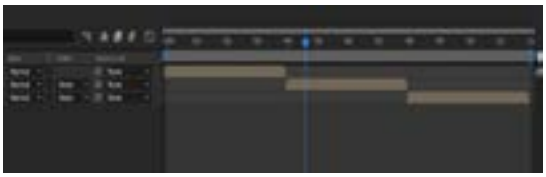


As we know a composition contains a timeline and that timeline can have multiple layers. What we may not know is that compositions can be placed or nested within other compositions. The benefit of nesting a composition is it compresses multiple layers in a single layer which will make file organization and applying effects much easier.

Now that we have our three skateboarding videos with masks and mattes setup let's put them all together into one composition. Create a new composition called *Skateboard Footage*. Set the settings to 720x480px, 30fps that is 12 seconds long.



Normally we may place an image or video into a timeline, but this time we will place an entire composition. Click and drag the composition *Skateboard-1* into the *Skateboard Footage* composition. When you drag the composition in you'll notice the name appear in the timeline as well as the composition iconto the left of the file name. Preview the scene and you see all of the elements of the *Skateboard-1* composition playing in our new composition. What is nice here is that *Skateboard-1* composition is being treated as a singe layer, rather than multiple layers, this makes it easy to work with in the timeline and in the composition window.

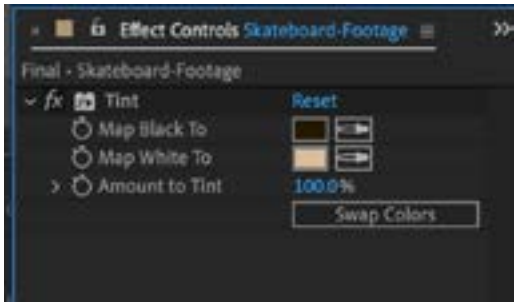


Drag *Skateboard-2* and *Skateboard-3* into the *Skateboard Footage* timeline and set them up tip-to-tail so that they play in order.

Create a Main Composition

Now that we have a composition called *Skateboard Footage* that contains all of our skateboarding videos let's bring it into a new composition. Once it is in our new composition we will apply effects to the skateboard video and apply the skateboard company logo on top.

Create a new composition called *Final*. Set the settings to 720x480px, 30fps that is 12 seconds long. Drag the *Skateboard Footage* composition into our new *Final* composition. The *Skateboard Footage* should come through as one layer. Use the *Preview* panel to play the layer to make sure all of the footage is in place.



Since all of the skateboard footage has been concendesed

into one layer, let's apply an effect to it. Apply the tint effect by going to *Effect > Color Correction > Tint* to apply the effect to the Skateboard Footage layer. Open the *Control Effects* tab and set the *Map Black To* a dark brown. Set *Map White To* a light yellowish brown, the result should look roughly like the image on the right.



Great! Now that we have our video background let's use it as the backdrop for the brand logo. Drag the file Skateboard Logo.ai into the timeline and place it above the *Skateboard Footage* layer. Scale and position into the center of the composition. Looks great! Let's also add a dropshadow to help the logo stand out from the background by going to *Effect > Perspective > Drop Shadow.*



Readjust Compositions

If you preview the scene you will see that the logo gets lost on the video background as the background is blank. It would be nice to add a background to the *Skateboard Footage* composition to help the logo stand out.



In the *Project* panel open *Skateboard Footage* composition again and click and drag *background.jpg* into the timeline, place it underneath the skateboard videos to add a scratchy, grungy background.



Return to the *Final* composition and you'll see that the *Skateboard Footage* layer has aleady updated.

Return to the *Skateboard Footage* composition and add the *Social Media Bug* to the lower right hand corner. Check that it appears in the *Final* composition.

Export

Great job! We covered alot here. With *Final* composition open in the timeline go to *Composition > Add to Render Queue*.

In the *Render Queue* look for *Comp Name* make sure it is set to *Final,* otherwise you may export the wrong composition.

Under *Render Settings* make sure it is set to *“Best Settings”.*

Under *Output Module* make sure it is set to *“Lossless”* make sure the format is set to either Quicktime or AVI.

Finall, use the *Output To* option save the animation to your Desktop with the label *lastname-skateboard-video.*

Submission

Upload your exported animation video format to your YouTube account. Publish the video and you will copy and paste the video URL to the submission page for the lab.

In addition to the final video url please upload the *lastname-skateboard-video.aep* file to Canvas for grading. Please do NOT submit all of the files or videos as those are large files, instead just upload the *.aep* project file for grading purposes.